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Time to turn over a new leaf

It's not our custom to shower praise on politicians, least of all provincial ones. But we'll turn over a new leaf this one week and applaud some of the moves the Ontario government took late in 1996.

Topping the list is the Victims' Bill of Rights at Queen's Park last fall. Too often victims of crime have been victimized a second time by a system that seems to cater more to the offender than the offended.

The bill is a first for Ontario, ensuring victims are notified, upon request, if the one who committed crime against them escapes police custody or makes application for release from a provincial institution.

A new program set for Lanark County will even put money toward that support. The Victim/Witness Assistance Program will provide \$120,000 in funding from the province and operate with two employees as well as with the backing of various agencies and volunteers.

It's part of a \$10.2 million Victims' Justice Fund which will, among other things, introduce an automated VNS or Victim Notification System. At its best, the system will keep victims better informed during all steps along the long road to justice.

The steps to date show the government has listened to the cries for help and have not turned a blind eye as many governments have before them.

On another front, the Harris Tories are also taking important steps to ensure dangerous drivers are removed from our roadways.

The first of these came back in November when the government introduced new rules for drunk drivers. Now, anyone who refuses a breathalyzer test or who takes the test and has a blood/alcohol count over the legal limit, will have their licence suspended for 90 days.

The administrative driver's licence suspension (ADLS) has already resulted in several drivers being taken off the roads in Lanark County.

And the new rule may have also had another effect. Over the five-week Christmas period, RIDE programs (Reduce Impaired Driving Everywhere) set up across the county resulted in only two impaired driving charges being laid. That's two from among the 3,830 motorists stopped and checked over that period.

Finally — finally — the harsh rules of the road may be starting to sink in with drivers here and across the province. This preventable crime, which results in 350 deaths in Ontario alone and countless more injuries, has been allowed to happen with feeble regulations and even weaker sentences.

Now, drivers who drink alcohol must think twice before climbing in behind the wheel or face losing their licence right there on the spot — no questions asked.

Take care on the ice

Just a reminder for the many snowmobile enthusiasts to take care before heading out on the area's frozen lakes and rivers. On Saturday, a Westport man was lucky to get away with just a minor case of hypothermia when the Yamaha V-Max he was riding crashed through the ice on the Westport Pond.

The driver, Peter McNickles, 26 was able to save himself although his machine sank to the bottom of the pond.

Before heading out, especially when conditions have been so unseasonably warm this winter, double check to make sure the ice won't give way. OPP suggest checking with local residents to ensure everything is solid.

A little prevention can go a long way to ensuring another person doesn't lose their life in vain. —R.C.

OPINION



The wonder of winter

Photo by Gena Gibson

Poetry Corner Christmas Days

Here's a final glimpse back at Christmas for those you still yearning for the festive season.

The tree, the tree, the Christmas tree
All dressed in glistening finery
Shiny balls and popcorn string
Flashing lights and bells a-ring

There underneath the presents lay
Till early morn on Christmas day
Then suddenly the silence breaks
Pandemonium and small earthquakes

The kids have spied the laden tree
All Santa's work is rent with glee
Those pretty gifts the night before
Are now dismantled on the floor

Skates and skis and teddy bears
Trucks and dolls with silken hair
Puzzles, balls and candy cane
Books and toys with funny names

Now comes the choice of which to play
And which can wait another day.
So many things to love at once
So much to try, no time for lunch

Too soon it's time for sleep again
No chance to try the choo-choo train
Nor taste the candies in my sock
And so to bed, it's nine o'clock.
Lorne V. Parker

Send us your letters to the editor!

House fire makes one feel fortunate

The wind chilled my fingers as I took pictures at the hole in the ground where Julie and Stuart Yeaman's house once stood. It was a cold Dec. 30, although I probably could have warmed myself if I had stood any closer to the still-smoking timber.

Even if it had been a warm day, I think I still would have felt a chill run through me. Seeing someone's home as a pile of burnt logs makes me realize, once again, just how lucky I am.

The Yeamans are lucky, too, that they have friends to make the whole ordeal easier. And none of the family was caught in the fire, although losing their cat and dog must make the loss more difficult.

Still, no matter how much the community has come together, there are things I would feel I couldn't replace.

For starters, my laptop computer. Oh, I know computers can be replaced easily, and it's just a

The Valley View

By Gena Gibson

frustrating piece of equipment that ate 55 pages of a story I was writing two years ago.

But now that story has become 200 pages, and if I lose it again, I'll cry for days rather than the hours I mourned last time the computer ate my hard work.

Then there are my other stories, which I haven't transferred onto the computer yet because they're not finished. These mean something to me, even if they never find themselves inside the covers of a real book.

For example, if I lost the book I wrote in high school, *There's Always*

Next Year, I would lose something very special to me. I haven't read it in years, and it just sits in my drawer gathering dust and not serving much purpose.

But it's MY manuscript, and reminds me just what I was doing when I didn't go to any parties or have any boyfriends or any kind of social life throughout my high school years.

Then there are pictures. I have photographs from my trip to Hilton Head, South Carolina, and these are pictures that can't be replaced. They can't be taken again, because the



person I went with isn't around to be in the pictures with me.

And pictures from the weekend trips I've taken with my sister, and our whirlwind trip to Edmonton, and various Christmas, New Year's and birthday photos.

In a tie with the photographs are my diaries, which I started when I was 11. I wouldn't want anyone else to read these, of course. Me at 14 is quite different than me at 24, and no one but ME needs to know the differences and similarities.

Still, what would I do without these diaries? They're not part of the necessities of life, I suppose, but they're the necessities of my life. They remind me of what I was, and what I wanted to be, and what I've become...and what I still want to be.

A television, a bed and clothes can easily be replaced, with some help and money. But if I lost my home to fire, it would be the memories I would mourn.

Acquaint yourself with the loving God

There is a scripture in the book of Job that I would like to quote. Job 22:21, "Now acquaint yourself with him and be at peace, thereby good will come."

In the new year we can have the awesome privilege of acquainting ourselves with God, we can know him personally. Our relationship is with a person, not a book.

That is not a put-down on the Bible, but as one hymn writer said, "Beyond the sacred page we seek thee."

The scriptures reveal to us what the person is like. The Bible reveals God as a Father, and the way to know God the Father is through Jesus Christ. Jesus said this; I am the way, the truth and the life, no one can come to the Father but by me.

Jesus revealed to us what the Father was like. There are certain aspects about God's character and nature that we need to know, and knowing these things can cause us to

Life Worth Living

By Jamie Robertson

live a full life or as the scripture said, Good will come.

We first need to know that God loves us. God is love. God so loved the world that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believed in him should not perish, but have everlasting life. God loves the world, all humanity, all races, and all nations, that he gave his son.

Then it is brought to each individual, God loves each person, and if a person believes in him they will

not perish. God sent his son to die and take our punishment for sin. There is no sin too great that Jesus's blood will not forgive. God's love cannot be measured.

How much does God love us? Jesus stretched his hand out one way, then the other way, and was nailed to a cross. His hands are still stretched out as an invitation to each of us saying, "Come to me, and I will give you life."

Another aspect of God's nature is



to realize God knows all things. He knows all about us. Nothing is hidden from him. In fact, God is so acquainted with us that even the very hairs of our head are numbered.

God knows all things, but there is one thing he chooses to forget. The Bible reveals that when we go to God and ask for forgiveness, our sins are cleansed away by the blood of Jesus, and God remembers them no more.

God's care for us is another characteristic of his nature. Peter said to cast out our anxieties and cares on the Lord, for he cares for you affectionately, and cares about you watchfully.

We are not a burden to him and he watches over us.

This is but a small picture of God's nature that we can know. This knowledge is not meant to be just head knowledge, but experiential, something we can experience every day.

Letters

Phone user upset with rate increase

To the editor:

By now most telephone customers in the Almonte and Carleton Place exchange areas have received a notice announcing an increase in local telephone rates effective this December. Ottawa customers rates will increase in March 1997.

I called Bell to enquire about the reason for this increase and was told that there was an explosion in the number of new lines required to service computers and fax machines. The basic service rate is set by the

quantity of telephone numbers one can reach when making a local call.

Even though I cannot communicate with computers and fax machines, I can dial their number and as such they are included in the total to set my basic rate. Once again the multitude of people that can't afford these machines are forced to subsidize those businesses and individuals that use them.

Businesses and individuals using these machines account for a major portion of the time that the carriers facilities are in use. Heavy users of the telephone system are normally charged a business rate which is higher than the basic residential rate.

However, many of these machines are now located in residences, some used for business and many as toys of the wealthy. Their usage patterns is very different from the normal telephone call. Many of these machines access the telephone lines and hold them for hours on end. Besides making an inordinate use of carrier facilities, they pose a potentially hazardous threat to the rest of us. There are only so many lines serving any area; if these are all in use then no new call can be made until a line becomes idle — it may not be possible to make an emergency call to the police, fire department or ambulance services.

There is something wrong when some people make infinitely greater use of a facility than most and yet everyone pays the same rate. Customers should pay for the use they make of a particular facility or service. A new local service tariff structure based on usage sensitive pricing (time and distance) would fit the bill nicely.

Another and better solution would be to permit competition in the provision of local telephone services via satellite and cable in the near future.

Yours sincerely,
J. Crowson
R.R. 3 Almonte